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The Sangha in Theravada Buddhism

Life is suffering. In Buddhism, it is believed that after death, people reincarnate and continue to experience this constant suffering. Buddhists understand this concept and shape their lives around it. In fact, “the distinctive feature of early Buddhism is that it made suffering and its elimination the core issue” (Smits, 10). People who successfully escape this reincarnation cycle of suffering and achieve *nirvana* are known as *arhats*. However, performing this feat requires intense discipline and meditation. As a core stepping stone to obtaining nirvana, followers of Theravada Buddhism gather in communities called *sangha* that provide environments to pursue discipline and *nirvana* (Smits, 15).

Like suffering, the *sangha* is a core component of Theravada Buddhism. Essentially, the *sangha* is “the community of followers” who practice the Buddha’s teachings (Smits, 15). This community includes both male monks and female nuns. To demonstrate perseverance towards discipline and escaping suffering, these followers must adhere to a strict set of rules known as the *Vinaya*. The *Vinaya* outlines practices that should be avoided such as sex, consuming alcohol, stealing, or lying about your spiritual progress. However, it also details expectations that significantly affect daily life in the *sangha*. For example, it is stated in the *Vinaya* that monks must renounce almost all of their possessions and may only keep essential things such

as robes and begging bowls (*Excerpts from the Vinaya*). Moreover, it is forbidden for the *sangha* to obtain food themselves (Flynn). As a consequence of these strict rules detailed in the *Vinaya*, the *sangha* must depend on laypeople.

The lifestyle described in the *Vinaya* forces the members of the *sangha* to depend on laypeople for the essential things they need to survive. While the *sangha* discourages monks from obtaining food themselves, it does allot time every day for monks to beg for food from the laypeople. While this may initially seem parasitical, the laypeople openly welcome this interaction with the *sangha*. Providing for monks benefits laypeople spiritually, and it allows them to obtain spiritual guidance from the *sangha* (Flynn).

Living in this simplistic and bare manner allows Buddhist followers to devote more time to another crucial aspect of becoming an arhat: meditation. Monks view meditation as a way to “live happily and peacefully” and to learn how to “be in harmony with the way things are in nature” (Flynn). Meditation is such a crucial component of *sangha* life that members of the *sangha* wake up early every day almost constantly practicing meditation (Flynn).

Ultimately, the main goal of Theravada Buddhism is to escape the reincarnation cycle of suffering and achieve *nirvana*. Joining the *sangha* is a requirement for becoming an *arhat* because it provides the correct environment to practice discipline and gain understanding. Through the *Vinaya* and its restrictions on daily life, monks learn and practice this self-control. Through the constant meditation encouraged in the *sangha*, monks gain the harmony and peace needed to end their suffering. In other words, the *sangha* remains to be a crucial step in pursuing the ultimate goal of attaining *nirvana* in Theravada Buddhism.

Works Cited

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